Little Fox Readers

Level 5

Journey to the West 106
The Question



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The Question





Guanyin looked at the messenger in surprise. "What is the problem?" she asked.

"It's about the Tang Monk," said the messenger. "To become a buddha, he needs to face one hundred challenges. I was just looking at the list of challenges he's faced. There are only 99 challenges on the list. He must face one more challenge to become a buddha!"



* * *

"We're moving so fast!" said the Tang Monk, smiling.

The travelers were flying back east. The guard from the Thunderclap Monastery was using a spell to carry them.

"I wish the whole journey had been this easy," said Bajie.

Wukong laughed. "Master was still mortal



before we reached the Western Paradise. He couldn't be carried then."

Wujing looked ahead. "We'll reach the Tang Empire soon."

Just then a messenger caught up with them. The messenger whispered something in the guard's ear. The guard glanced quickly at the travelers. Then he looked back at the messenger and nodded.



Instantly the spell broke, and the travelers fell from the sky. *Bam!* They slammed into the ground next to a wide river.

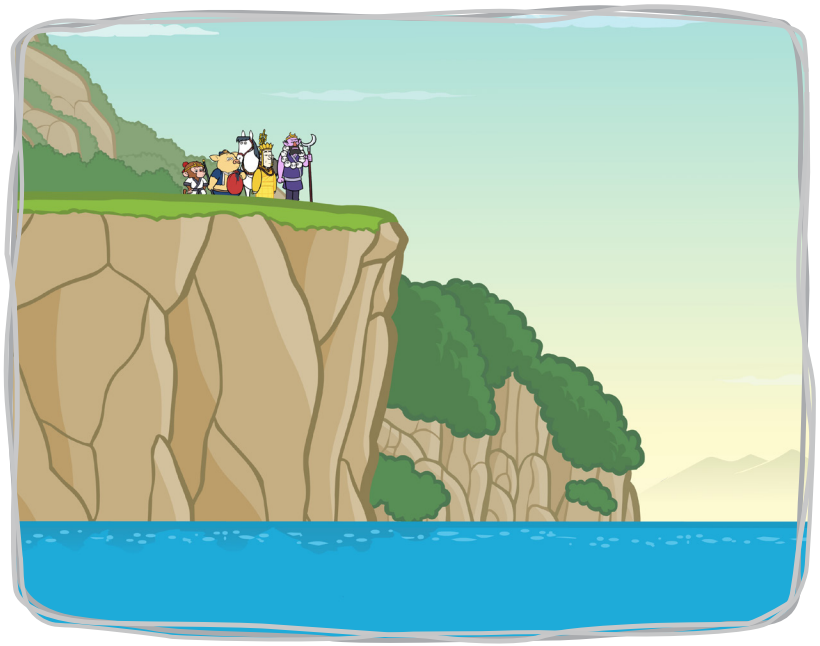
Wukong stood up and saw the guard and messenger flying back west. The monkey shook his head.

"What happened?" The Tang Monk stood up and brushed dirt from his robe. "Why did the guard drop us?"



“I’ll tell you why,” said Bajie. “He’s a villain! He thinks it’s funny to drop people!” The pig waved his fist at the guard, who was now far away. “Villain!”

Wukong turned slowly to the Tang Monk. “I think I know why he dropped us, Master. You must face one hundred challenges in order to become a buddha. “You probably got to the Western Paradise before you’d faced



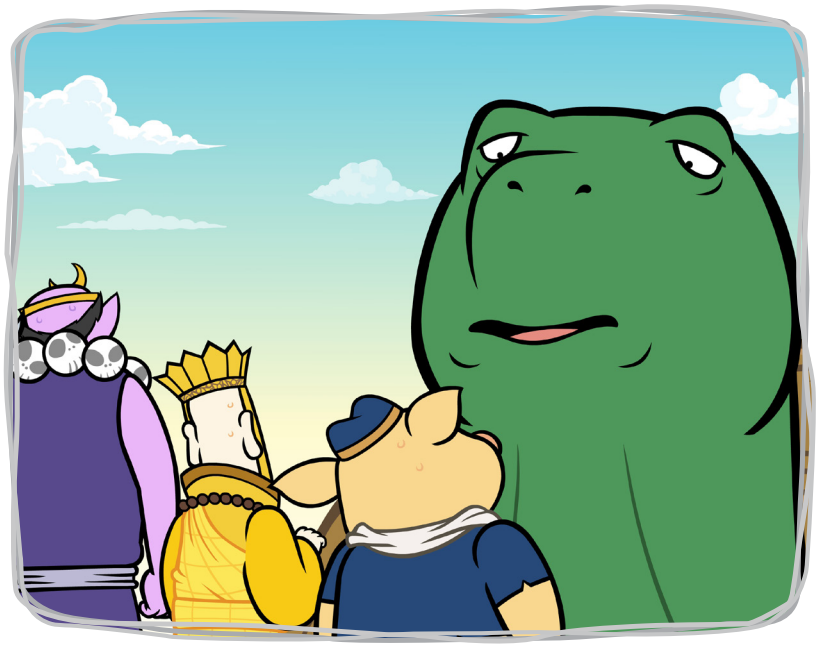
all of them.”

“Oh no.” The monk trembled. “So other bad things must happen now?”

Wukong nodded. “I hope there won’t be too many more problems.”

“The first problem is crossing this river,” said Wujing.

“It looks familiar,” said the monk. “We must have crossed it during the journey west.”



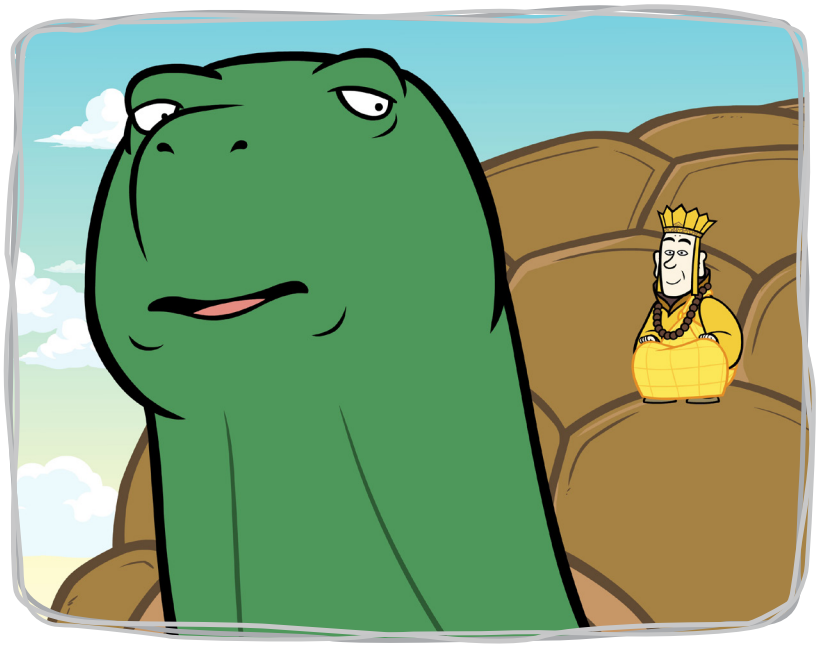
Suddenly a large form rose from the river. It was an enormous turtle.

"Greetings," said the turtle. "Do you remember me?"

The travelers all smiled.

"Yes, we do," said the Tang Monk. "You carried us over this river many years ago."

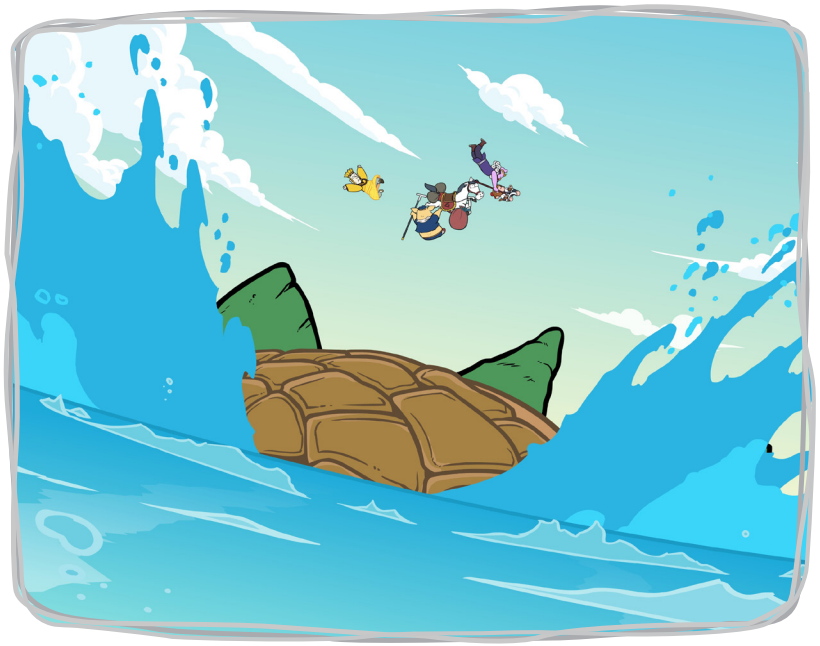
"Yes," said the turtle. "And I will gladly carry you across again. Hop onto my back."



The travelers climbed on, and the turtle started across the river. Wujing and Bajie soon fell asleep while Wukong meditated. The Tang Monk stayed awake too, sitting near the turtle's head.

"Did you reach the Western Paradise?" asked the turtle.

"Yes," said the Tang Monk. "It is a wonderful place. We are now returning to the



east so I can deliver the True Scriptures."

"Good," said the turtle. "Did you ask Buddha when I would be reborn as a human?"

The monk bit his lip. He had forgotten to ask the turtle's question!

"You're not answering," said the turtle.

"I'm sorry," said the monk. "I, uh—"

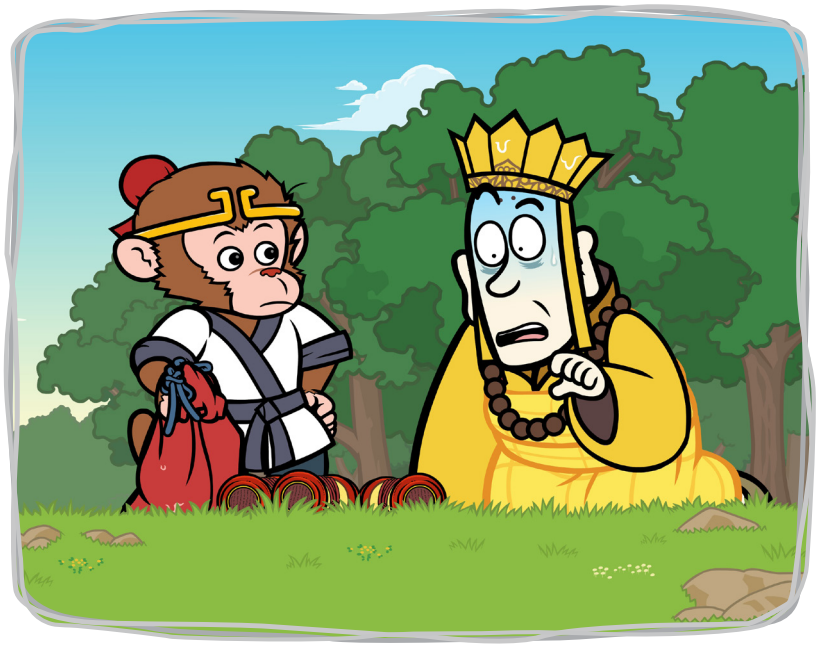
Splash! The turtle suddenly dived under the water, dumping everyone off his back.



Wukong's eyes flew open as he hit the cold water. He leaped into the air. Bajie, Wujing, and the horse quickly flew across the river. But the Tang Monk was thrashing furiously in the rushing water.

"Help!" yelled the monk.

Wukong cast a spell and lifted the monk and the bags from the river. When everyone was on dry land, the monkey turned the bags



upside down. Water poured out, followed by the scrolls. They were soaked.

"The True Scriptures!" cried the Tang Monk. "They're ruined!"